

“We took Richmond at 8:15 this morning ... The enemy left **in great haste ... ”**

UNION GENERAL GODFREY WEITZEL, IN A TELEGRAM TO GRANT, APRIL 3, 1865

The fall of Richmond

With Petersburg fallen, Richmond could not be defended. As soon as Lee had telegraphed Jefferson Davis that April 2 morning to abandon the city, the evacuation had commenced. Orders were given to torch everything of military or strategic value.

After the civil authorities had departed, the city was unpoliced and the conflagrations spread uncontrolled until the first Union detachments arrived next morning to accept the city's formal surrender and to begin dousing the flames. By then, much of the Southern capital was in ruins; an estimated 25 percent of its buildings had burned down, and remaining hopes for the Confederacy lay smoldering.